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Psychiatry and its historians

ANDREW SCULL*

Until the last two decades, psychiatric history was written primarily by amateurs, and a peculiar group of amateurs at that – psychiatrists themselves. Occasionally, as in the case of Ida MacAlpine and Richard Hunter,[1] the extraordinarily prolific and erudite mother/son team, and in William Parry-Jones's definitive history of private English madhouses,[2] this situation has produced work that, notwithstanding its elements of partiality, has been of lasting value and significance. In the more usual case, however, the resulting distortions have seriously compromised the scholarly usefulness of the accounts offered – creating versions of the past that serve (in ways generally obscured from their authors) to legitimate the profession's present-day activities; or that represent a harmless form of antiquarianism but largely fail to satisfy the elementary canons of good historiography.[3]

Psychiatrists turned historians were not the only offenders in this regard. An earlier generation of administrative historians approached psychiatric history in singularly uncritical fashion, accepting at face value psychiatry's claims to ground its practice on the firm and neutral ground of value-free natural science, and all-too-readily equating intention with accomplishment, the language of reform with its practical realization. Such 'responsible' and sanitized history has received, as might be expected, a warm welcome in many quarters, coinciding as

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[1] See especially Richard Hunter and Ida MacAlpine, *Three Hundred Years of Psychiatry* (London: Oxford University Press, 1963), a magisterial source book; *idem, Psychiatry for the Poor* (London: Dawson, 1974); Ida MacAlpine and Richard Hunter, *George III and the Mad Business* (London: Allen Lane, 1969); and the series of introductions they wrote for editions of classic psychiatric texts published by Dawsons.

[2] William Parry-Jones, *The Trade in Lunacy* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1972).

[3] See for example, Franz Alexander and S. Selesnick, *The History of Psychiatry: An Evaluation of Psychiatric Thought and Practice from Prehistoric Times to the Present* (New York: Harper & Row, 1966); Gregory Zilboorg, *A History of Medical Psychology* (New York: Norton, 1941); Walter Bromberg, *Man Above Humanity: A History of Psychotherapy* (Philadelphia: Lippincott, 1954); J. H. Schultz, *Psychotherapie: Leben und Werk grosser Ärzte* (Stuttgart: Hippokrates-Verlag Marquardt, 1952). For a recent unregenerate example of the genre, revelatory of profound ignorance and/or hostility and misunderstanding of a whole generation of non-psychiatric histories of psychiatry, see John Crammer, *Asylum History: Buckinghamshire County Pauper Lunatic Asylum – St John's* (London: Gaskell, 1990).

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it does with the received wisdom propagated by those whose claim to moral authority over the mad is sanctioned at once by law and by duly certified scientific expertise. Psychiatric history was here cast as a morality tale, a movement from the dark period when lunacy was not seen as a condition requiring medical treatment, through a drawn-out struggle in which the steady application of rational-scientific principles by people of good will produced halting and irregular but unmistakeable evidence of progress towards humane and effective treatments for those afflicted with the various forms of mental alienation – a process supposedly culminating in our present state of grace.[4]

Such is, I think, the essential message of an earlier generation of psychiatric historians. And it must be said that many psychiatrists, comfortable with this bowdlerized version of history, have reacted with dismay and even fury as more recent scholarship has moved away from this comfortable and comforting vision of the past.[5] The sources of the counter-transference are not hard to discern. The first generation of revisionist histories often produced an equally Manichean version of psychiatry's past, albeit one that was a veritable mirror image of its predecessor's. Where one tradition saw the asylum as a beacon of Enlightenment and hope, the iconoclastic challenge to received wisdom portrayed it as a fatally mistaken and profoundly repressive institution. Where psychiatrists liked to think of their ancestors (and themselves) as decent, humane, honourable scientists, they now encountered portraits of the profession as little better than concentration camp guards, manufacturers of a mythical entity called 'mental illness'.[6] Where an earlier focus on 'Great Men' had practically deified Tuke and Pinel as liberators of the mad, Foucault and his followers now denounced them as perpetrators of 'a gigantic moral imprisonment'.[7]

Such polemical excess turned out, of course, to be as problematic and ultimately unpersuasive as the equally one-sided view it sought to replace.[8]

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[4] For an early French text, see René Semelaigne, *Les Pionniers de la psychiatrie française avant et après Pinel*, 2 volumes (Paris: Baillière, 1930–1932); for an English example, see Kathleen Jones, *Lunacy, Law, and conscience, 1744–1845: The Social History of the Care of the Insane* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1955); and for an American version of the genre, see Albert Deutsch, *The Mentally Ill in America*, 2nd edition (New York: Columbia University Press, 1949). Deutsch was rewarded with an honorary membership in the American Psychiatric Association; and Jones was invited to deliver a Maudsley lecture ('Scull's Dilemma', *British Journal of Psychiatry*, cxli (1982), 221–26) and continues to be cited routinely by British psychiatrists themselves as having written the definitive history of their specialty – a judgement with which few historians would concur.

[5] See, for example, Sir Martin Roth, 'Psychiatry and its critics', *British Journal of Psychiatry*, cxxii (1973), 374–402; and Roth and Jerome Kroll, *The Reality of Mental Illness* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986). See also Crammer, *Asylum History*, preface.

[6] The *locus classicus* of these views is, of course, the work of Thomas Szasz – himself, ironically enough, a renegade psychiatrist. See, for example, *The Myth of Mental Illness*, revised edition (New York: Harper & Row, 1974); *The Manufacture of Madness* (New York: Dell, 1970).

[7] Michel Foucault, *Madness and Civilization: A History of Insanity in the Age of Reason* (New York: Pantheon, 1965).

[8] For critiques of Szasz from outside the ranks of organized psychiatry, see, for instance, Peter Sedgwick, *Psychopolitics* (London: Pluto, 1982), Ch. 6, and Michael S. Goldstein, 'The politics of Thomas Szasz: A sociological view', *Social Problems*, xxvii (1980), 570–83. Foucault, of course,

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Nonetheless, this anti-psychiatric movement was clearly of considerable importance in provoking a broader interest in the history of psychiatry – helping to persuade a whole generation of younger professional historians in France, in Britain, in Germany, and in the United States that madness deserved a fresh look; that its history could constitute a serious intellectual subject, one worthy of sustained attention and investigation. Paralleling the development of an 'externalist' approach to the histories of science and medicine, the history of psychiatry now began to attract a very different kind of scholarly attention.

Very noticeably, much of this first generation of what some have termed revisionist historiography[9] shared one of the most striking features of Foucault's work: a resistance to being stuck within the confines of the narrowly circumscribed historical monograph; and a tendency instead to favour a broader synthetic treatment of social responses to madness over periods of a century and more. Entirely characteristic, also, was the resort to implicit or explicit comparative analysis and references. These were extraordinarily ambitious studies in their own right, even if they lacked some of the rhetorical ostentation and the full temporal sweep of Foucault's original. One thinks here, for instance of Robert Castel's *L'ordre psychiatrique*,[10] of Klaus Doerner's *Madmen and the Bourgeoisie*,[11] David Rothman's *The Discovery of the Asylum*,[12] Gerald Grob's conservative counter-blast, *Mental Institutions in America: Social Policy to 1875*,[13] and, of course, my own *Museums of Madness*.[14]

To stress that these studies *shared* an interest in providing a broad-gauged assessment of social responses to madness on a macroscopic scale should not lead us to overlook the equally profound differences of emphasis which serve to divide them from one another, casting doubt on any facile assimilation of this

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continues to enjoy the status of a cultural icon in some quarters. For criticism, see Erik H. C. Midelfort, 'Madness and civilization in early modern Europe: A reappraisal', in B. C. Malament (ed.), *After the Reformation* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1980), 247–65; and Andrew Scull, 'A failure to communicate? On the reception of Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* by Anglo-American historians', in Arthur Still and Irving Volody (eds), *Rewriting the History of Madness* (London: Routledge, 1991). (This volume contains a variety of essays on Foucault, some friendly, some highly critical.)

[9] For a critique of the notion that there is a single 'revisionist' history of psychiatry, see Andrew Scull, *Social Order/Mental Disorder: Anglo-American Psychiatry in Historical Perspective* (Berkeley: University of California Press/London: Routledge, 1990), Ch. 2.

[10] Robert Castel, *L'Ordre psychiatrique: L'Age d'or de l'aliénisme* (Paris: Minuit, 1976), English translation, *The Regulation of Madness: Origins of Incarceration in France* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988).

[11] Klaus Doerner, *Bürger und Irre* (Munich: Europäische Verlagsanstalt, 1969), translated as *Madmen and the Bourgeoisie* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1981).

[12] David Rothman, *The Discovery of the Asylum* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1971). A new edition, containing Rothman's response to his critics, appeared from Little Brown in 1990.

[13] Gerald Grob, *Mental Institutions in America: Social Policy to 1875* (New York: Free Press, 1973).

[14] Andrew Scull, *Museums of Madness; The Social Organization of Insanity in Nineteenth-Century England* (London: Allen Lane, 1979). A revised and expanded second edition of this monograph will be published by Yale University Press in 1992.

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work into a single school of 'revisionist' historiography of psychiatry. Interestingly enough, many of the differences fall along national lines, with French, German, English and American scholarship adopting very different approaches to the subject, which reflect in turn quite distinct conceptual and theoretical presuppositions.

Castel, as is perhaps natural for a French scholar, can be seen as the most directly linked to Foucault's work, amplifying the latter's ideas, and extending them to encompass a discussion of the real 'great confinement', the rise of the nineteenth-century asylum, and the associated consolidation of mental medicine. Both here and in his later collaborative work on the United States as an 'advanced' psychiatric society,[15] the state is essentially peripheral to the analysis, which stresses far more the role of psychiatry, not just in policing norms, but in creating them. Power, as Foucault would have it, is viewed in this line of analysis as 'productive', as serving to construct and manage certain forms of subjectivity, and psychiatry takes its place as one of the primary disciplines engaged in the measurement and monitoring of all aspects of organized social life which is so characteristic of modern forms of social control.[16]

Klaus Doerner's *Madness and the Bourgeoisie* is, by contrast, embedded in a very different intellectual tradition. In some ways, his is the most ambitious of all these volumes, since it seeks, in a systematic fashion, to encompass developments in Britain and France, as well as Germany, and ranges from the eighteenth all the way through to the mid-nineteenth century. What is equally distinctive, however, is its close theoretical linkages with twentieth-century German social theory, especially with the work of Habermas and with critical theory more generally. Readers will differ in how far they find this strategy helpful – it certainly lends a turgid and opaque quality to Doerner's prose – but substantively, it leads to a characteristic focus on the connections between the emergence of psychiatry and the 'metamorphosis of the institutions of enlightened absolutism', the peculiarities of Enlightenment rationality, and the development of 'industrial-capitalist bourgeois society'; and to a series of ruminations on 'whether psychiatry is more of an emancipatory or integrative science'.[17]

Doerner's work, then, is notable for its explicitly comparative approach, the self-conscious attempt to marry the concerns of history and continental sociology, and the particular matrix within which the birth of psychiatry is seen

[15] See Françoise Castel, Robert Castel and Ann Lovell, *La société psychiatrique avancée* (Paris: Éditions Grasset, 1979); translated as *The Psychiatric Society* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1982).

[16] For a sympathetic critique of this tradition, see the discussion in David Ingleby, 'Professionals as socializers: the "Psy Complex", pp. 79–109 in Steven Spitzer and Andrew Scull (eds), *Research in Law, Deviance, and Social Control*, Volume 7 (Greenwich, Connecticut: JAI Press, 1985).

[17] Doerner, *Madmen and the Bourgeoisie*, 17, 290–91.

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to be embedded. Along each of these dimensions, it differs profoundly from American scholarship of the same era. Rothman and Grob, Doerner's most prominent American counterparts, are in most respects mutually antagonistic and dismissive of each other. The former does draw upon sociological insights to some extent, but surprisingly looks primarily to the essentially ahistorical work of the American Erving Goffman for inspiration.[18] The latter appears to view all forms of sociology with scepticism, seeing the discipline as virtually inviting anachronism and oversimplification when imported into historical work. But notwithstanding the contempt and hostility they offer each other, Rothman and Grob share at least the common ground of an emphasis on the distinctiveness of their own country's experience – a claim which I think has some validity but which both push much too far.[19] The correlative of their stress on the uniqueness of American psychiatry is a resistance which amounts almost to a deliberate distancing of their work from contemporary European scholarship.[20]

Regardless of internal differences and divisions, however, taken as a whole this generation of historical studies clearly provided a very rich theoretical and historiographic context within which a new generation of psychiatric historians has worked and, in some national settings at least, has flourished. In the past decade and a half, global reinterpretations of entire epochs have rather gone out of fashion (though Roy Porter's treatment of the long eighteenth century in England,[21] and Jan Goldstein's[22] and Ian Dowbiggin's[23] work on nineteenth-century France constitute at least partial exceptions to this generalization). Rather, we have seen the creation of an ever more varied and innovative set of

[18] Rothman's attempt to suggest underlying similarities in changing American responses to madness, crime, poverty, delinquency and so forth, and to suggest that the various forms of segregative social control evolved in essentially homologous directions, seemed to many readers to be heavily indebted to Goffman's arguments about 'total institutions', as outlined in *Asylums: Essays on the Social Situation of Mental Patients and Other Inmates* (Garden City, New York: Doubleday, 1961). Rothman has subsequently confirmed that this was indeed the case. See 'An interview with David Rothman', *Canadian Criminology Forum*, iv (1982), 152–62.

[19] For commentary on their work, see Scull, *Social Order/Mental Disorder*, Ch. 2.

[20] Rothman seems unaware of Doerner's work (which was available only in German when he wrote *The Discovery of the Asylum*). But his doubts about this sort of enterprise are explicit in his rejection of Foucault's work as 'so caught up in ideas that their base in events is practically forgotten' (*Discovery of the Asylum*, xvii). Grob resists explanations which emphasize the role of structural factors in constraining, prompting and channelling human activities in particular directions, is cautious about generalizations which he sees as 'oversimplifying complex social processes' (*Mental Institutions*, 2–3), and views historical outcomes as the product of a series of incremental changes, each of which is entitled to virtually equal explanatory weight. It follows, therefore, that he is actively and overtly hostile to the sorts of theorizing which are so central a feature of the work of his European counterparts.

[21] Roy Porter, *Mind Forg'd Manacles: A History of Madness in England from the Restoration to the Regency* (London: Athlone, 1987).

[22] Jan Goldstein, *Console and Classify: The French Psychiatric Profession in the Nineteenth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).

[23] Ian Dowbiggin, *Inheriting Madness: Professionalization and Psychiatric Knowledge in Nineteenth-Century France* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991).

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researches, which have served to push back both the temporal and the topical boundaries of the historiography of psychiatry, but which have done so while stressing the local and the detailed, rather than national patterns and large-scale social processes.

This development has not necessarily marked any loss of nerve or of intellectual ambition. Indeed, most of these more narrowly focused studies have clearly been inspired by the earlier generation of revisionist analyses, and often quite explicitly seek to refine or refute some of the assertions made in these larger surveys of the terrain. More or less self-consciously, however, the new generation of work represents an attempt to break out of an increasingly stale and ultimately unsatisfying debate about the metaphysics of reform and the benevolence or otherwise of the psychiatric enterprise, into which the field threatened for a period to subside. In place of abstract and often angry polemics about the history and the anti-history of psychiatry,[24] we are seeing the emergence of a more nuanced portrait, rooted in more careful archival work and successfully challenging earlier orthodox and counter-orthodox histories.

Michael MacDonald's extraordinary reconstruction of the country practice of Richard Napier,[25] an Anglican divine-cum-astrological physician who specialized in the treatment of the mentally disturbed, has afforded us telling insights into the multiple and overlapping interpretations of madness which flourished in seventeenth-century England, and begun the process of recasting our understanding of the 'naturalization' of Western ideas about insanity. Jonathan Andrews,[26] in a thesis which for the first time begins to exploit the rich materials housed in the archives of the Bethlem Hospital, has transformed our understanding of the institution that had previously stood as the very symbol of the *ancien régime* madhouse.[27] Bedlam and the history of eighteenth-century encounters with unreason have finally begun to receive serious historical scrutiny.[28] And appropriately, Bedlam's antithesis, and the institution which played so vital a role in the lunacy reform movement of the next century, has also attracted its historian, and for the first time we have a demythologized portrait of the daily operations of the York Retreat.[29]

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[24] Cf. Peter Sedgwick, *Psychopolitics* (London: Pluto Press, 1982).

[25] Michael MacDonald, *Mystical Bedlam: Madness, Anxiety and Healing in Seventeenth Century England* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981).

[26] Jonathan Andrews, 'A History of Bethlem Hospital c. 1600–c.1750' (Ph.D. diss., London University, 1991).

[27] See Patricia Allderidge, 'Bedlam: fact or fantasy', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 17–33.

[28] See also Porter, *Mind Forg'd Manacles; idem*, 'The rage of party: a Glorious Revolution in English psychiatry?' *Medical History*, xxvii (1983), 35–50; Andrew Scull, 'The domestication of madness,' *Medical History*, xxvii (1983), 233–48; and Stanley Jackson's introduction to William Pargeter's *Observations on Maniacal Disorders* (London: Routledge, 1988; 1st ed., Reading: for the author, 1792).

[29] Ann Digby, *Madness, Morality, and Medicine: A Study of the York Retreat, 1796–1914* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1985).

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The detailed reconstruction of the history of a single institution has, indeed, been one of the growth industries of the past decade. At one extreme, we have several probing studies of psychiatry for the rich: Nancy Tomes's dissection of the Pennsylvania Hospital under Kirkbride;[30] Charlotte MacKenzie's and Trevor Turner's complementary studies of Ticehurst, the madhouse favoured by the English aristocracy;[31] and my own examination of the Crichton Royal Asylum in Scotland.[32] At the opposite end of the spectrum, the barracks-asylum for the poor has begun to acquire an individual identity, as historians explore how far particular asylums correspond to or diverge from the picture drawn in an earlier generation of global histories.[33]

One welcome aspect of the shift towards a more microscopic view has been a heightened attention to the inmate experience. David Ingleby's quip, that the historiography of psychiatry, 'like the histories of colonial wars, [tells] us more about the relations between the imperial powers than about the "third world" of the mental patients themselves',[34] – all-too-accurate in its time – begins here to lose its sting. Reconstructing the patients' world has, indeed, become another fashionable arena of study, as analogously has the process of giving voices to the voiceless in social history more generally, and one can anticipate a spate of new work of this sort in the next few years.[35]

Equally, there have been attempts to reach out beyond the confining walls of the asylum to examine the origins of non-institutional psychiatry. William Bynum and Bonnie Blustein have explored the tension-filled relations between neurology and psychiatry in late nineteenth-century Britain and the United

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[30] Nancy Tomes, *A Generous Confidence: Thomas Story Kirkbride and the Art of Asylum Keeping, 1840–1883* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984).

[31] Charlotte MacKenzie, 'A Family Asylum: A History of the Private Madhouse at Ticehurst in Sussex, 1792–1917' (Ph.D. diss., University of London, 1987); *idem*, 'Social factors in the admission, discharge, and continuing stay of patients at Ticehurst Asylum, 1845–1917,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 147–174; Trevor Turner, 'A Diagnostic Analysis of the Casebooks of Ticehurst Asylum 1845–1890' (M.D., University of London, 1990).

[32] Andrew Scull, *The Asylum as Utopia: W.A.F. Browne and the Mid-Nineteenth-Century Consolidation of Psychiatry* (London: Routledge, 1991).

[33] S.E.D. Shortt, *Victorian Lunacy: Richard M. Bucke and the Practice of Late Nineteenth-Century Psychiatry* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986); Laurence Ray, 'Models of madness in Victorian asylum practice', *European Journal of Sociology*, xxii (1981), 229–64; John Walton, 'The treatment of pauper lunatics in Victorian England: the case of Lancaster Asylum,' in A. Scull (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad-doctors and Madmen: The Social History of Psychiatry in the Victorian Era* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1981), 166–97; Ellen Dwyer, *Homes for the Mad: Life Inside Two Nineteenth-Century Asylums* (New Brunswick, New Jersey: Rutgers University Press, 1987).

[34] David Ingleby, 'Mental health and social order,' in S. Cohen and A. Scull (eds.), *Social Control and the State: Historical and Comparative Essays* (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1981), 142.

[35] See, for example, Roy Porter, *A Social History of Madness* (London: Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1987); Edward Shorter, 'Women and Jews in a private nervous clinic in late nineteenth-century Vienna,' *Medical History*, xxxiii (1989), 149–83; *idem*, 'Mania, hysteria and gender in Lower Austria, 1891–1905,' *History of Psychiatry*, i (1990), 3–31; John Walton, 'Casting out and bringing back in Victorian England: pauper lunatics, 1840–1870,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 132–46; and Jonathan Andrews, '"In her vapours . . . [or] in her Madness"? Mrs Clerke's case: an early eighteenth-century psychiatric controversy,' *History of Psychiatry*, i (1990), 125–44.

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States.[34] Martin Stone has delineated the impact of shellshock on the organic prejudices of early twentieth-century British psychiatry,[37] and the subsequent expansion of psychiatric technologies into the workplace.[38] And drawing upon Foucauldian ideas, Nikolas Rose has explored the penetration of psychiatric ideas into the most intimate recesses of the social body.[39] Such work has begun to fill in the details of what has hitherto remained an intellectual Africa, the history of twentieth-century psychiatry.[40] Even the history of psychoanalysis, hitherto largely the preserve of the sectarians themselves, has begun to attract attention from outside the ranks of the true believers.[41]

Greater attention to the patient and the treatment setting has also brought with it a heightened interest in the content and the therapeutics of psychiatric disorders. Alongside what Mark Micale has called 'linear intellectual histories of diseases and their diagnosis,'[42] such as the work of Stanley Jackson[43] and German Berrios,[44] there have also appeared a series of studies, more clearly influenced by the newer social history of psychiatry, which seeks to trace the linkages between psychiatric theorizing and its political, cultural and professional context. For France, for instance, Ian Dowbiggin has examined the rise of hereditarian ideas and connected them to a crisis of legitimacy among French

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[36] William Bynum, 'The nervous patient in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Britain: the psychiatric origins of British neurology,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 1, 89–102; Bonnie Blustein, 'New York neurologists and the specialization of American medicine,' *Bulletin of the History of Medicine*, liii (1979), 170–83; *idem*, '"A Hollow Square of Psychological Science": American neurologists and psychiatrists in conflict,' in Scull (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad-Doctors and Madmen*, 241–70.

[37] Martin Stone, 'Shellshock and the psychologists,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds.), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 242–71.

[38] Martin Stone, 'The military and industrial roots of clinical psychology in Britain, 1900–1945' (Ph.D. diss., University of London, 1985).

[39] Nikolas Rose, *The Psychological Complex: Psychology, Politics, and Society in England 1869–1939* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1985); *idem, Governing the Soul: The Shaping of the Private Self* (London: Routledge, 1990).

[40] See also the discussion in the latter portions of Andrew Scull, 'Psychiatry and social control,' *History of Psychiatry*, ii (1991), 149–169.

[41] See, for example, Robert Castel, *Le psychanalysme* (Paris: UGE, 1976); Anthony Clare, 'Freud's cases: the clinical basis of psychoanalysis,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 1, 271–288; John Forrester, 'Contracting the disease of love: authority and freedom in the origins of psychoanalysis,' in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 255–270; Frank Sulloway, *Freud: Biologist of the Mind* (New York: Basic Books, 1979).

[42] Mark Micale, 'Hysteria and its historiography: the future perspective,' *History of Psychiatry*, i (1990), 38. This essay (which appears in *ibid*, 33–124), and a two-part companion piece ('Hysteria and its historiography: a review of past and present writings,' *History of Science*, xxvii (1989), 223–261; 319–351), provide an intelligent and wide ranging survey of both older and more recent scholarship on hysteria, together with some useful commentary on psychiatric historiography more generally.

[43] Stanley Jackson, *Melancholia and Depression: From Hippocratic Times to Modern Times* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1986).

[44] German Berrios, 'Stupor: a conceptual history,' *Psychological Medicine*, xi (1981), 677–88; *idem*, 'Delirium and confusion in the 19th century: a conceptual history,' *British Journal of Psychiatry*, lxxxix (1981), 439–40; *idem*, 'Obsessional disorders during the nineteenth century: teminological and classificatory issues', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 1, 166–87.

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psychiatrists in the last third of the nineteenth century;[45] and Jan Goldstein has suggested connections between the diagnosis of hysteria and the politics of anti-clericalism in the Third Republic.[46] Focusing on English materials, Stephen Jacyna has explored the professional interests that lay behind the adoption of somatic theories of mind by Victorian psychiatrists;[47] and Michael Clark has sought to account for the fascination with the concept of morbid introspection and the general resistance to psychological accounts (and therapies) for mental disorder in late Victorian Britain.[48]

On a broader canvas, the question of therapeutics, both routine[49] and extraordinary, has been attracting a growing number of historians. From sexual surgery to psychosurgery,[50] from hypnosis to hypnotics,[51] what has been done to and for the psychiatric patient has been shown to be still another avenue for exploring the peculiarities of the history of madness. And the discovery that these therapeutic inteventions have been disproportionately directed at the female of the species has formed part of a larger concern with the intersections of gender and mental disorder.[52]

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[45] Ian Dowbiggin, 'French psychiatry, hereditarianism, and professional legitimacy, 1840–1900,' *Research in Law, Deviance, and Social Control*, vii (1985), 135–65.

[46] Jan Goldstein, 'The hysteria diagnosis and the politics of anti-clericalism in late nineteenth-century France', *Journal of Modern History*, liv (1982), 209–39.

[47] L. S. Jacyna, 'Somatic theories of mind and the interests of medicine in Britain, 1850–1879,' *Medical History*, xxvi (1982), 233–58.

[48] Michael Clark, '"Morbid introspection", unsoundness of mind, and British psychological medicine, c. 1830 – c. 1900', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 3, 71–101; *idem*, 'The rejection of psychological approaches to mental disorder in late nineteenth-century British psychiatry', in Scull (ed.), *Madhouses, Mad-Doctors, and Madmen*, 271–312.

[49] W. L. Jones, *Ministering to Minds Diseased* (London: Heinneman, 1983).

[50] Andrew Scull and Diane Favreau, '"A chance to cut is a chance to cure": sexual surgery for psychosis in three nineteenth-century societies', *Research in Law, Deviance, and Social Control*, viii (1986), 3–39; Eliot Valenstein, *Great and Desperate Cures: The Rise and Decline of Psychosurgery and Other Radical Treatments for Mental Illness* (New York: Basic Books, 1986); Jack Pressman, 'Uncertain Promise: Psychosurgery and the Development of Scientific Psychiatry in America, 1935 to 1955' (Ph.D. diss., University of Pennsylvania, 1986); and, for a different form of surgical intervention, see Andrew Scull, 'Desperate remedies: a gothic tale of madness and modern medicine', *Psychological Medicine*, xvii (1987), 561–77.

[51] Ann Harrington, 'Metals and magnets in medicine: hysteria, hypnosis, and medical culture in *fin-de-siècle* Paris', *Psychological Medicine*, xviii (1988), 21–38; *idem*, 'Hysteria, hypnosis and the lure of the invisible; the rise of neo-mesmerism in *fin-de-siècle* French psychiatry', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 3, 226–46; Andrew Scull, *Decarceration* (Oxford: Polity/New Brunswick, New Jersey: Rutgers University Press, 1984), Ch. 6; Judith Swazey, *Chlorpromazine and Psychiatry* (Cambridge, Mass.: M.I.T. Press, 1974).

[52] See, for instance, Elaine Showalter, *The Female Malady* (New York: Pantheon, 1985); Andrew Scull, *Social Order/Mental Disorder*, Ch. 11; Carroll Smith-Rosenberg and Charles Rosenberg, 'The female animal: medical and biological views of woman and her role in nineteenth-century America', *Journal of American History*, lx (1973), 332–356; Smith-Rosenberg, 'The hysterical woman: sex roles and role conflict in nineteenth-century America', *Social Research*, xxxix (1972), 652–78; Dianne Hunter, 'Hysteria, psychoanalysis, and feminism: the case of Anna O.', *Feminist Studies*, ix (1983), 464–88; Michael MacDonald, 'Women and madness in Tudor and Stuart England', *Social Research*, liii (1986), 261–81.

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I have said nothing here about the sophisticated recent treatments of the intersection between psychiatry and the law.[53] Nor, for that matter, have I examined the recent revival of psychiatric biography, freed from the constraints of the 'great man' approach to history.[54] But I trust that I have covered enough territory to show that the history of psychiatry may be said to be flourishing as never before, a state of affairs to which the convening of the first European Congress and the founding of a European Association for the History of Psychiatry offer their own indirect testimony.

Still, the growth and consolidation of a more systematic and sophisticated approach to the field have clearly proceeded unevenly, and only in the Anglo-American world have historians of psychiatry begun to translate the intellectual ferment of the past two decades into the sort of institutional presence that alone can provide the basis for a more secure future. Our sense of optimism about an expanding interest in the history of psychiatry must be tempered, therefore, by a realistic sense of the obstacles that still inhibit the emergence of this subject as a mature field of professional study – with all that is thereby implied about, for instance, the development of systematic programmes of training for neophytes; about the existence of a cohesive and stable community of scholars capable of defining research agendas for the field and agreeing upon criteria by which to assess psychiatric historiography; and about the associated structural arrangements that necessarily underpin and lend a sense of intellectual continuity and institutional identity to any academic discipline.

The essays which follow on the state of the subject in Sweden, in the Netherlands, in Belgium, and Italy reveal the still precarious and marginal position occupied by those specializing in psychiatric history in those countries. Even in France and Germany, where some of the seminal texts which launched the new interest in madness were produced, historians of psychiatry never obtained a secure institutional niche within the universities. Partly as a consequence, the flow of new work has slowed, and the range of topics being studied has diminished in recent years. Robert Castel, for instance, has lost interest in the field, and moved on to study 'the social question' more generally. His place has been taken, not so much by a new generation of French scholars, as by a number of historians trained in Britain and North America who have

[53] Cf. Roger Smith, *Trial By Medicine: Insanity and Responsibility in Victorian Trials* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1981); Ruth Harris, 'Murder under hypnosis in the case of Gabrielle Bompard: psychiatry in the courtroom in Belle Époque Paris', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 2, 197–241; *idem*, *Murders and Madness: Medicine, Law and Society in the fin-de-siècle* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1989).

[54] See, for example, Andrew Scull, 'A brilliant career? John Conolly and Victorian psychiatry', *Victorian Studies*, xxvii (1984), 203–35; Trevor Turner, 'Henry Maudsley: psychiatrist, philosopher, and entrepreneur', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 3, 151–89; William Parry-Jones, '"Caesar of the Salpêtrière": J.-M. Charcot's impact on psychological medicine in the 1880s', *Bulletin of the Royal College of Psychiatrists*, xi (1987), 150–3; and Bonnie Blustein, 'A New York Medical Man: William Alexander Hammond, M.D. (1828–1900)' (Ph.D. diss. University of Pennsylvania, 1979).

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chosen to focus their attention on France.[55] German scholarship, meanwhile, has understandably become obsessed with the horrors of the Nazi 'solution' to the problems posed by the mentally ill, but in the process has tended to neglect the remainder of its rich and fascinating national experience.

In Britain and North America, by contrast, research into the history of psychiatry has continued to gain momentum. Institutionally, the growing strength of the field is easy to document. There is, of course, the publication of *History of Psychiatry*, the first English-language journal devoted to the subject. Importantly, however, papers on the subject have appeared with great regularity in a whole series of other journals – such as *Medical History, Bulletin of the History of Medicine, History of the Human Sciences, Social History of Medicine, Journal of Social History*, and *Psychological Medicine* – not only providing further evidence of the explosion of new work in the area, but also drawing the attention of scholars working in closely related disciplines to the range, depth, and sophistication of the research now being produced by historians of psychiatry. The increasing prominence of the field has led scholarly societies to devote whole congresses to work on the history of madness.[56] A bi-weekly seminar at the Wellcome Institute for the History of Psychiatry attracted an internationally distinguished array of speakers, continued for two full academic years, and eventually produced a three-volume collection of papers from some of the best younger historians working on the subject.[57] The Squibb Corporation has endowed an annual lecture series at the Institute of Psychiatry, and most of the first sixteen lectures given in the series have recently been republished in a single volume.[58] And in the United States, Eric Carlson under the auspices of the Cornell Medical Center in New York City has provided an important forum for bringing together historians of psychiatry to discuss work in progress.

These institutional developments have depended in their turn, of course, on the growing popularity of the history of psychiatry as a field for Ph.D.

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[55] See the books published by Goldstein and Dowbiggin cited above; Goldstein's 'The hysteria diagnosis and the politics of anti-clericalism'; a series of further papers by Dowbiggin, including 'Degenerationism and hereditarianism in French mental medicine 1840–90', in W. F. Bynum, R. Porter and M. Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness,* Volume 1 (London: Tavistock, 1985), 188–232; *idem*, 'French psychiatric attitudes towards the dangers posed by the insane ca.1870', *Research in Law, Deviance, and Social Control*, ix (1988), 87–111; *idem*, 'Alfred Maury and the politics of the Unconscious in nineteenth-century France', *History of Psychiatry* i (1990), 255–288; Ruth Harris, 'Murder under hypnosis in the case of Gabrielle Bompard'; and Ann Harrington, 'Hysteria, hypnosis, and the lure of the invisible: the rise of neo-mesmerism in *fin-de-siècle* French psychiatry', in Bynum, Porter and Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, Volume 3, 226–246.

[56] For example, the 1983 meeting of the Canadian Association for the History of Medicine in Vancouver; and the 1989 meeting of the Society for Eighteenth-Century Studies at Notre Dame University, South Bend, Indiana.

[57] W. F. Bynum, R. Porter and M. Shepherd (eds), *The Anatomy of Madness*, 3 volumes, 1985–88.

[58] R. M. Murray and T. H. Turner (eds), *Lectures on the History of Psychiatry* (London: Gaskell, 1990). As Murray and Gaskell comment in their introduction, the growing sophistication and scholarly ambition of these lectures, when read chronologically, itself testifies to the discipline's development over the past decade and a half.

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dissertations, a flow of new scholars which is, of course, of crucial significance for the future vitality of the field. Already, many of this younger generation of historians have begun to achieve notice and even prominence in the discipline: in North America, one thinks of such figures as Nancy Tomes, Bonnie Blustein, Jan Goldstein, Ian Dowbiggin, Mark Micale, Constance McGovern, Ann Harrington, and Ellen Dwyer; in Britain, of Nicholas Hervey, Jonathan Andrews, Mark Finnane, Stephen Jacyna, Charlotte MacKenzie, Richard Russell, Janet Saunders, Michael Clark, Ruth Harris, D. J. Mellett, and Larry Ray. Together with an array of more established (though not generally Establishment) scholars – Michael MacDonald, Roy Porter, Gerald Grob, William Bynum, Roger Smith, Edward Shorter, Elaine Showalter, Ann Digby, Nikolas Rose, Joan Busfield, Samuel Shortt and John Walton, to name just some of the more prominent figures – their continued commitment to exploring the history of psychiatry provides a firm foundation on which to build. Much will now depend on the establishment of a similar institutional base and network of scholars elsewhere in Europe.

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